



2 BILLION

THE NUMBER OF PEOPLE WHO WATCHED THE BRITISH ROYAL WEDDING

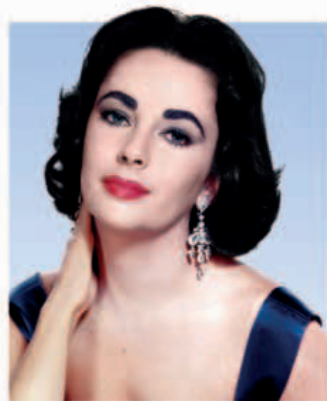


estimated 181 people. It was the worst disaster in New Zealand in 80 years.

Japan experienced its most powerful **earthquake** since records began on March 11. Measuring 9.0 on the Richter scale, the earthquake struck the northeast coast, causing a massive **Tsunami**. A wall of water racing inland swept away cars, ships, and buildings. The official death toll was 14,000, but many thousands were missing and the cost to human life is not yet fully known. A **state of emergency** was declared at a **nuclear power plant** in Fukushima, where pressure exceeded normal levels,

leading to worldwide concerns about a nuclear disaster. By May, the plant showed little sign of calming down, and officials announced a complete cold **shutdown** by the end of the year.

The world was suffering from a **financial hangover** in 2011, as austerity measures began to bite. A bailout package given to Ireland and Greece in 2010 had been intended to stop their **euro debt crisis** from spreading to the rest of Europe, but whispers of a **bailout in Portugal** were enough to put stocks on shaky ground and raise fears that Spain was also in trouble. A bailout for Portugal was awarded on May 17. Eurozone ministers met in the same month to staunch the market's anxieties about **Greece, Portugal, and Ireland**, amid concerns that these countries would be unable to meet the repayments on their loans.



Elizabeth Taylor
One of the Hollywood greats, British-born American actress Elizabeth Taylor died on March 23 at the age of 79.

The future of the **single currency** looked **uncertain**. But it was not all gloom for the euro, as Germany and France saw their economies grow.

Terrorism struck again in the heart of **Russia**, as two suicide bombers blew themselves up at Domodedovo Airport in Moscow, on January 24, devastating the international arrivals hall and killing dozens of people. They were believed to be Islamist militants from the North Caucasus.

Italy grappled with problems of a different sort as its leader, **Silvio Berlusconi** (b. 1936), who had shown a knack for surviving charges of corruption, faced new charges in February of having sex with an underage girl. The scandal, combined with the poor state of the country's finances, lost Berlusconi his key supporters.

The bitter debate over the **Tea Party movement** (see 2009) in the US and its inflammatory right-wing rhetoric was reignited when Democratic Congresswoman **Gabrielle Giffords** was shot in the head during a public meeting in Tuscon, Arizona. Six people were killed in the attack on January 8, but Giffords survived.

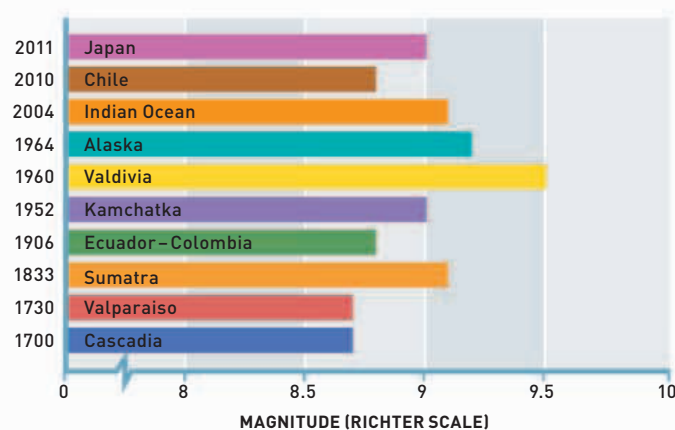
President Obama continued to have a tough time exerting his authority, and budget cuts, on a reluctant Congress. Bickering between Republicans and Democrats was intense, and Republicans pushed for even greater cuts. The US Congress finally passed a budget bill in April

that would cut \$38.5 billion in government spending over the rest of the existing fiscal year. Obama's attempts to spotlight positive initiatives were swamped by the crush of news from Japan, Egypt, and Libya.

Criticism of Obama's leadership was overshadowed by the news that **Osama Bin Laden** (b. 1957), the leader of al-Qaeda and the most hunted man in the world, had been **killed** on May 1 in a fire-fight with US forces in Pakistan. The news sparked an outpouring of emotion across the US, but led to immediate fears of retaliation. Retaliation was, indeed, swift. The Pakistani Taliban carried out a double **suicide bombing** on May 13 that killed 80 recruits at a military training center in the northwest of the country.

A shaken world

The earthquake in Japan was the fifth largest since records began—this graph shows the magnitude of the 10 biggest earthquakes in history.



Death of Bin Laden

Osama Bin Laden, hunted for three decades, made headline news around the world after his death at the hands of US special forces.

Only days after the dramatic events of Osama Bin Laden's death, the world's last known combat veteran of World War I, **Claude Choules**, died peacefully in Australia at age 110. He had served in both World Wars. Conflict shaped his life, and he became a staunch pacifist. His death marked the moment the Great War passed from living memory into the history books.

